



'THE OVERALL MEDAL TALLY IN PARIS FELL SHORT OF EXPECTATIONS, HIGHLIGHTING THE NEED FOR STRATEGIC IMPROVEMENTS IN TRAINING AND INFRASTRUCTURE'

numbers are slowly increasing now. The maximum benefit has come from the Khelo India Games.

We are also bolstering athlete preparation through advanced sports science, enhanced training regimes, improved talent identification, and increased funding for grassroots and elite development programmes. We have also released an Olympic Guidebook to assist NSFs and administrators in enhancing India's preparedness for the LA 2028 Olympic Games. The guidebook presents a well-structured, time-bound approach to streamline planning, coordination, and progress tracking for the Games.

Given that sport is a state subject, what initiatives can the central government take to ensure access to quality sports infrastructure in every district?

The central government plans to incentivise state governments through funding, public-private partnerships, and community-based programmes to ensure that every district benefits from improved sports facilities.

There are over 1,000 Khelo India Centres — i.e., one KIC in almost every district. This amounts to handholding state governments from

the district level itself. Please remember that sport is a state subject as per the constitutional scheme, and the primary onus is on the state governments. The Government of India has guided and empowered them through Centres of Excellence, Khelo India Centres, Khelo India Academies, infrastructure creation and upgradation, and capacity building.

I have been travelling across the country over the last six-seven months, and in many States, I observed a lack of proper maintenance of existing infrastructure. There is also a shortage of quality coaches, which the State governments must address.

The central government's primary role is to pay more attention to our elite athletes and prepare them for international events. However, the Prime Minister, Shri Narendra Modi Ji, through Khelo India, has ensured that we also reach the grassroots. Hopefully, State governments will be inspired to further develop sport and ensure more children get a chance to play.

Should CSR funding for State Sports Development Funds be extended?

Extending CSR contributions to

State-level funds could boost regional sports development. However, a robust framework ensuring transparency and targeted impact would be essential to integrate such funding effectively.

Should private sector involvement in grassroots and elite sports development be increased? If so, how can it be effectively integrated?

The government supports the PPP model because it is necessary for further development of sport. There are many stadiums, even in Delhi, but their utilisation is very low, whereas the maintenance costs are very high. The PPP model can ensure better commercial utilisation of our stadiums.

The private sector can bring in investment and expertise, and we can ensure that sports infrastructure is available at the district, tehsil, and village levels. Effective integration requires structured public-private partnerships, transparent funding channels, and clearly defined roles to foster the development of grassroots and elite sport. We have several innovative models in mind:

- One corporate adopting one discipline/sport for grassroots and elite levels
- Corporates setting up High-Performance Centres
- Corporates establishing tech-driven talent identification and incubation systems
- State governments collaborating with corporates

There is also a need for more CSR funding to start flowing into the sports sector.

What tangible results have the